

Munasinghe-Fernando Travel Magazine

CHINA

Beijing · The Forbidden City · The Great Wall

★ SIX CENTURIES OF EMPIRE



FORBIDDEN CITY



THE GREAT WALL

INSIDE: **Where 24 emperors ruled** for five centuries · a **rainy day in the palace** in cheap blue ponchos · **the Great Wall at Mutianyu** by cable car · a four-year-old who **walked the whole Forbidden City** · and the kindness of a stranger in the Beijing rain

Who we are, why we travel.



We're the Munasinghe-Fernandos — two parents and three children who love to see the world *together*. My husband and I share one dream: to travel to as many countries as we possibly can, as a family.

It's never easy — booking flights, trains and rooms for five is its own small adventure, and we know we can't reach everywhere. But from every country we do get to, we try our very best to see as much as we can. This magazine is where we keep all of it.

China was where the whole journey began. Our three — Avisha, Aviann and Avin — stood on the central axis of the Forbidden City on our very first morning abroad, blue shoe-covers on their feet and a whole continent of adventures still ahead of them.

— *The Munasinghe-Fernandos, 2026*

Welcome to the Middle Kingdom

Beijing was where our adventure began — and where it ended. Two stopovers, one outbound and one homebound, bracketed an entire summer across Europe. On the way out we touched down at 04:40, watching a grey dawn break over an airport already humming in Mandarin. On the way home we did the same in reverse — same city, same dry morning air — but a whole summer of memories heavier.

Our one full day in the capital was a wet one. Rain swept Tiananmen Square and the Forbidden City, and

we walked six hundred years of imperial history in cheap blue ponchos, damp to the knees and grinning. In between the two stopovers lay China's gift to the world: the largest palace on earth, and the Great Wall snaking across mountains so steep we could scarcely believe human hands had built it.

This is the first issue of our travel magazine — a record of one family of five, moving through China hand in hand, eyes wide, and a thank-you to the country that gave the trip its biggest history lesson and its first great adventure.

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One month. Fifteen countries. It begins here.

Every issue of this magazine is one country — and every country is one chapter of the same journey: one family of five, thirty nights on the road, from the Great Wall of China to the top of Europe and home again.

This is where it starts. We fly out of a New Zealand winter, land in Beijing, and the map unrolls from there — the Alps, the Danube, the canals and cathedrals, all the way to a day inside the world's smallest country — before Beijing catches us one last time on the way home. This page sits at the front of every issue: it will always tell you where we've been, where we are, and where we're headed next.

THE ROUTE · 15 COUNTRIES · 33 CITIES · 30 NIGHTS

- 01 China ★

02 Austria

03 Czechia

04 Hungary

05 Slovenia

06 Italy

07 Switzerland

08 Germany

09 France

10 Netherlands

11 Belgium

12 Denmark

13 Sweden

14 Vatican

△ Home

Today — China: where it all begins. Beijing's Forbidden City on the way out, the Great Wall on the way home.

One month. Three kids.

Two seasons in one bag.

This was the biggest journey we had ever attempted — one month, five of us, three of them children — packed in the cracks between work and school runs. On a trip this long there is no room for mistakes; every item had to earn its place. The strangest part of all: we were leaving the middle of a New Zealand winter and landing in the thick of a European summer, so the jumpers stayed home and we packed, instead, for heat we couldn't yet feel.

We packed to a rule — light and simple for every day, but always one sensible backup tucked behind it. When it was finally done, the whole month fit into two large backpacks and four small ones, plus a single hand-luggage bag packed just for the China stopover — and, for four-year-old Avin, a little backpack of his own with a strap for us to hold. A stroller and three folding car seats rounded it out. Backpacks, not suitcases — because three children and cobblestones don't mix with wheels.

01

Two Seasons, One Bag

Two shorts, two dresses and a set of active wear each — plus two spare dresses, for when a dress beats shorts. The boys, Avisha and Avin, in shorts by day with one pair of trousers held in reserve; Aviann in dresses, with hair bands, and oil and gel for their hair.

SUMMER CLOTHES ONLY

02

Feet & Sun

A pair of shoes and a pair of walking slippers each — hard soles for the sightseeing miles, soft ones for tired feet. Then the sun armour: sunscreen, five pairs of sunglasses, bucket hats, a refillable bottle each, and aloe gel for the evenings.

SUN KIT FOR FIVE

03

The Medicine Bag

Panadol, ibuprofen and cetirizine — every one in both tablets and syrup, so there's a dose for every age. Throat lozenges, Quick-Eze for bloating, nasal spray, plasters and wound cream.

A DOSE FOR EVERY AGE

04

School on the Road

Three weeks out of term, so school came too. A daily journal each; Avisha's two Narnia books and Aviann's Charlotte's Web — their Term 3 reading, read ahead; online homework along the way; and a colouring book and activity book for Avin.

TERM 3, IN ADVANCE

05

Three Little Cameras

One small camera each, from Shein, so all three could shoot their own view of the trip. The hard part was hunting down three 32GB micro-SD cards — the one size the little cameras would take.

3 CAMERAS · 3 PHOTOGRAPHERS

06

The Clever Finds

Three folding car seats from Kmart — 2.5 kg each, lightweight and packable. European adapters for every charger. Eye masks with a built-in pillow, so small heads can sleep upright on the long flight. And a stash of home: instant noodles, soup, mac & cheese and 3-in-1 coffee, for the late and hungry arrivals.

2.5 KG CAR SEATS · A TASTE OF HOME

Rain, no raincoats, and a map that lied.

Our first hour in China was a crash course in how to actually travel here — a WeChat shuttle in the dark, payment apps that had to be juggled, a taxi that took three times longer than Google promised, and a fistful of cheap ponchos bought against the rain.

FRI 10 JUL 2026 CAPITAL AIRPORT → HOTEL → FORBIDDEN CITY LANDED 04:30 · WET



The 100-yuan note — blue ponchos in front of the Great Hall of the People, holding up cash you can barely spend here, where the phone is the wallet.

China begins the moment you land — and it does not wait for you to catch up. We touched down at half past four in the morning, bleary and wired, three children draped over us like coats. One small mercy in the dark: we had packed a single hand-luggage bag for exactly this stopover, so while other families queued at the belts, we walked straight past baggage claim and out into the cool, wet Beijing morning. A message to our hotel over WeChat, and a shuttle appeared to carry us in.

Half past four in the morning, three sleeping children, one bag between us. The China-only carry-on earned its place before the sun was even up.



First ponchos in the rain — five of them, damp but undefeated, by the Monument to the People's Heroes on Tiananmen Square.

Then the first plan came undone. Our guide messaged ahead — it's raining at the Forbidden City, bring your raincoats — and ours, of course, were folded neatly inside the main luggage we had just sailed past. So our very first purchase in China was a fistful of cheap ponchos. Paying for them was its own adventure: WeChat Pay refused several of our cards, and we fell back on AliPay, grateful we had loaded different cards onto different apps before we left. Here cash is nearly extinct; your phone is your wallet, and a backup wallet is not paranoia — it is planning.

The last lesson came on the road. Google Maps promised the collection point was thirty minutes away. Ninety minutes later we were still crawling through wet Beijing traffic — because Google cannot see China's live congestion at all. It was the Didi app, checked on a hunch, that told us the truth. Rule one, learned before breakfast: in China, trust Didi, not Google. Ponchos on and phones charged, we drove on into the rain — toward six hundred years of emperors.

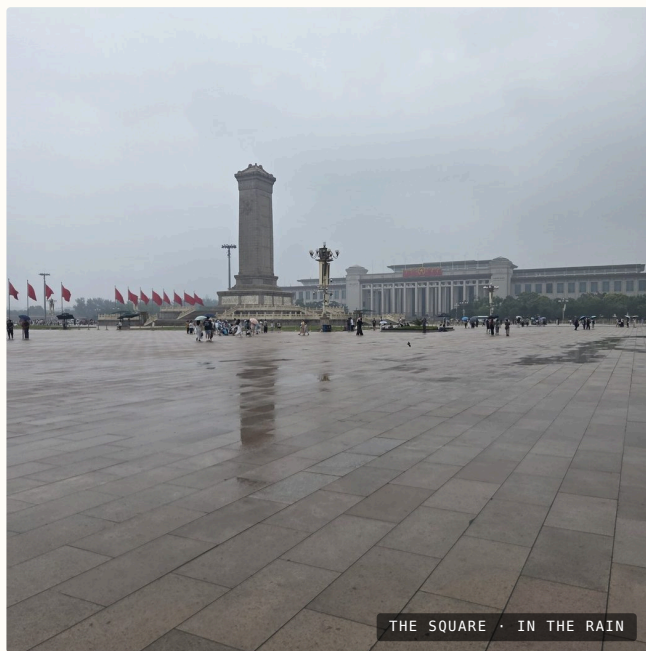
The threshold to *the palace.*

To reach the Forbidden City you first cross the largest public square on earth — and on our day it lay grey and glistening under a steady summer rain.



★ GATE OF HEAVENLY PEACE

Tiananmen — the Gate of Heavenly Peace — is the ceremonial front door to the Forbidden City, its portrait of Chairman Mao between two slogans: "Long live the People's Republic of China" and "Long live the great unity of the world's peoples." We posed beneath it in the drizzle, selfie-stick up, before joining the queue north into the palace.



★ A MODERN HISTORY

Beyond the flags stand the Monument to the People's Heroes and the National Museum, and near them these marble reliefs of marching figures — the square's newer, revolutionary chapter, laid out on the same grand axis the emperors once used.



A walled city, once forbidden.

Six centuries ago the Ming emperor Yongle raised the largest palace on earth at the very centre of Beijing — and forbade the world from setting foot inside it.

BEGUN 1406 · FINISHED 1420 THE FORBIDDEN CITY, BEIJING MING & QING · 1420–1912



A HALL BEHIND THE INNER GOLDEN-WATER MOAT

Yellow-tiled roofs, vermilion walls and the marble-railed Golden Water winding through the inner court — the palace's geometry of stone, water and tile, softened by a grey and rainy sky.

Construction began in 1406 under the Yongle Emperor, third of the Ming, who had shifted the capital from Nanjing to Beijing to anchor his northern empire. More than a million workers — carpenters, stone-cutters, gilders and masons — laboured for fourteen years. Whole trunks of precious *nanmu* wood were floated down rivers from the south-west, and paving-stones and marble dragged across frozen winter roads slicked with well-water. In 1420 the palace stood complete: some 980 surviving buildings and, by tradition, close to nine thousand rooms, across 72 hectares, ringed by a moat 52 metres wide and walls 10 metres tall.

Its Chinese name, Zijincheng — the "Purple Forbidden City" — encodes its meaning. "Purple" points to the Pole Star, the still centre of heaven where the celestial emperor was said to dwell; the earthly emperor's palace was its mirror on the ground. "Forbidden" was literal. From 1420 until 1912, no commoner could pass its gates without imperial leave; to enter uninvited was to invite death.

"The emperor was the Son of Heaven, and only Heaven was permitted ten thousand rooms — so, the story goes, he stopped at 9,999."

The genius of the place is its geometry. The palace sits astride Beijing's grand north-south axis, aligning the Son of Heaven with the cosmos, its great halls all facing south toward his subjects. It falls into two worlds: the *Outer Court* to the south, where the state was governed and ceremonies held, and the *Inner Court* to the north, the private realm of the emperor, his empress and consorts. Twenty-four emperors of the Ming and Qing ruled here until 1912, when the six-year-old Puyi abdicated and two thousand years of imperial rule ended. What was sealed against the world for five centuries is now the Palace Museum — a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1987, open at last to the very millions once barred at its gates.

Anatomy of the palace.

Every colour, number and beast in the Forbidden City means something. A short guide to what we were actually looking at, in the rain.



中和殿 · THE INNER THRONE

The Hall of Central Harmony

Behind the great ceremonial hall sits this smaller throne room, where the emperor paused to rest and rehearse before rites. The gold board above reads 允執厥中 — "hold you fast the middle way," a Confucian maxim on ruling with balance.



GUARDIANS · 銅獅

The bronze lions

A pair guards every important gate — and whether a lion's eyes, ears or mouth are carved *open* or *closed* is a quiet lesson. **Open** means *watch closely, pay attention*; **closed** means *look away, let it pass* — so lions at different gates were given different messages about what to notice and what to ignore. The male also rests a paw on a ball (the emperor's power over the world), the female on a cub (the line that must go on).



COLOUR & AXIS

Yellow roofs, red walls

The glazed roof-tiles are imperial yellow — the colour of earth and the centre, reserved for the emperor alone. The walls are vermilion, for power and joy. Every major hall faces south down a single mile-long axis, so the ruler sat with his back to the north, facing his realm.



WATER & STONE

The Golden Water

A bow-shaped channel, the Inner Golden Water, curves through the first great court, crossed by five marble bridges for the five Confucian virtues. Part drainage, part feng-shui, part sheer beauty — and, on our day, brimming with rain.

1406–20

BUILT UNDER YONGLE

72 ha

≈180 ACRES, 980 BUILDINGS

~8,700

ROOMS ("9,999")

24

EMPERORS · MING & QING

A childhood dream, one wet room at a time.

Raised on Chinese and Korean historical dramas, walking through the real palace — hall after hall, courtyard after courtyard — was a dream I had carried for years. The rain only made it gentler.

FRI 10 JUL 2026 THE FORBIDDEN CITY EVERY ROOM • THE WHOLE LIST



ALL FIVE • ON THE MARBLE RAMP

A family selfie on the great ramped stairway between the halls, the throne rooms climbing behind us — three little cameras swinging from three small necks, and blue shoe-covers on every foot.

We reached the meeting point four minutes early and stood in the drizzle while our guide waited another five for the stragglers.

Then the gates opened, and everything I had hoped for was on the other side. I grew up on Chinese and Korean historical dramas — on palace intrigues and throne rooms and emperors in silk — and to walk through the real thing, hall after hall, courtyard after courtyard, every room on our list, was a dream years in the making. We saw all of it.

*“I grew up watching emperors on a screen. Today
I walked through their palace, one room at a time
— in a plastic poncho, in the rain.”*

The weather, oddly, was on our side. Beijing in July can be punishing, but the rain kept the worst of the heat off us — even if, by the end, we were damp with a mix of drizzle and sweat. To protect the ancient timber floors, we padded through the halls in blue cloth shoe-covers, which the children thought hilarious. Our one real mistake was Avin's stroller: we had left it behind, so our four-year-old walked the entire palace on his own small legs. He managed. Barely. So did we.

The adventure came on the way home. We ordered a Didi back to the hotel — but Beijing has a dozen hotels with almost the same name, and the one we tapped was the wrong one. Our driver, who spoke no English, delivered us confidently to the wrong door. What could have been a crisis became the kindest moment of the day: he simply phoned our real hotel, got the address, drove us there himself, and refused a single yuan extra. Not every wrong turn ends badly. Some end in a stranger's quiet kindness.

Three little *photographers.*

Each of the three had packed a little camera of their own — and in the Forbidden City they used them, framing the halls, the moat and each other with enormous seriousness. Here they are, all three, lenses at the ready.



★ SMALL HANDS, BIG PALACE

Avisha and Aviann framed the halls with great care; Avin, four, mostly pointed his camera at his own shoe-covers and the backs of people's knees. Behind them the outer court opens out — acre after acre of grey flagstone between the red walls, every gilded eave a photograph worth taking, and taking again.

” Somewhere on three little memory cards is the whole Forbidden City, shot at knee height, slightly blurred, and absolutely theirs. ”

A good lunch, a fever, and a 2:50am flight.

It had begun with grins under the arrivals screen at dawn; by the end of this long day we would be back at that very airport, boarding into the dark — by way of a cheap, delicious lunch and one small worry we didn't see coming.

FRI 10 — SAT 11 JUL 2026 BEIJING → THE NIGHT FLIGHT WHEELS UP 02:50



CAPITAL AIRPORT · 04:40 · "WELCOME TO BEIJING"

The whole family under the glowing arrivals screen at dawn, jet-lagged and grinning at the very start of it all — a full day later we would pass this same terminal on the way out.

Back at the hotel and finally dry, we did the most rewarding thing a traveller can do: we walked out with no plan and let the neighbourhood decide. A few streets away we found a small restaurant, sat down, and ate one of the best lunches of the day — fresh, generous, and so cheap we checked the bill twice. Then a hot bath, and a grateful nap.

Our flight out left at ten to three in the morning, and the hotel shuttle ran only until half past nine at night. So we set an alarm for half past eight, peeled ourselves off the beds, and rode out into the dark toward the terminal.

“Ten to three in the morning, three children asleep on our shoulders — one of them warmer than he should have been.”

It was at the airport that the day turned tender. Avin said he felt cold, so I pulled a jumper over him. It was only after security that a health officer approached us gently: the thermal scanners had flagged that our littlest was running a minor fever. Poor Avin — four years old, halfway around the world, quietly running a temperature. We held him closer as we boarded. A note from further down the road: there was nothing to fear. He was simply exhausted; we let him sleep the whole flight, kept the water coming, and by Germany the fever had lifted and our littlest was himself again.

The city, on a plate.

Between the palace and the plane we ate the way you do with three tired children — a big East-meets-West hotel breakfast, a cheap neighbourhood lunch, and not a single formal banquet in sight.

THE ATOUR · BEIJING BREAKFAST BUFFET + A NO-NAME LUNCH FUEL FOR A RAINY DAY



Breakfast at the Atour — fried rice, waffles and egg under a painted palace on the wall. Aviann went straight for the waffles; Avin negotiated terms with a spoon.

The Atour's morning buffet was its own small adventure — a spread where fried rice, stir-fried greens and steamed buns sat cheerfully beside waffles, fried eggs and cocktail sausages. The children built plates that made no culinary sense whatsoever and were entirely delighted with them.

Our best meal of the whole stopover never made it to a camera: a tiny neighbourhood place a few streets from the hotel, no menu we could read,



A grown-up's plateful — ribbon noodles, cumin-dark beef, shredded pork with garlic stems and fried rice, with little breakfast sausages and bacon on the side.

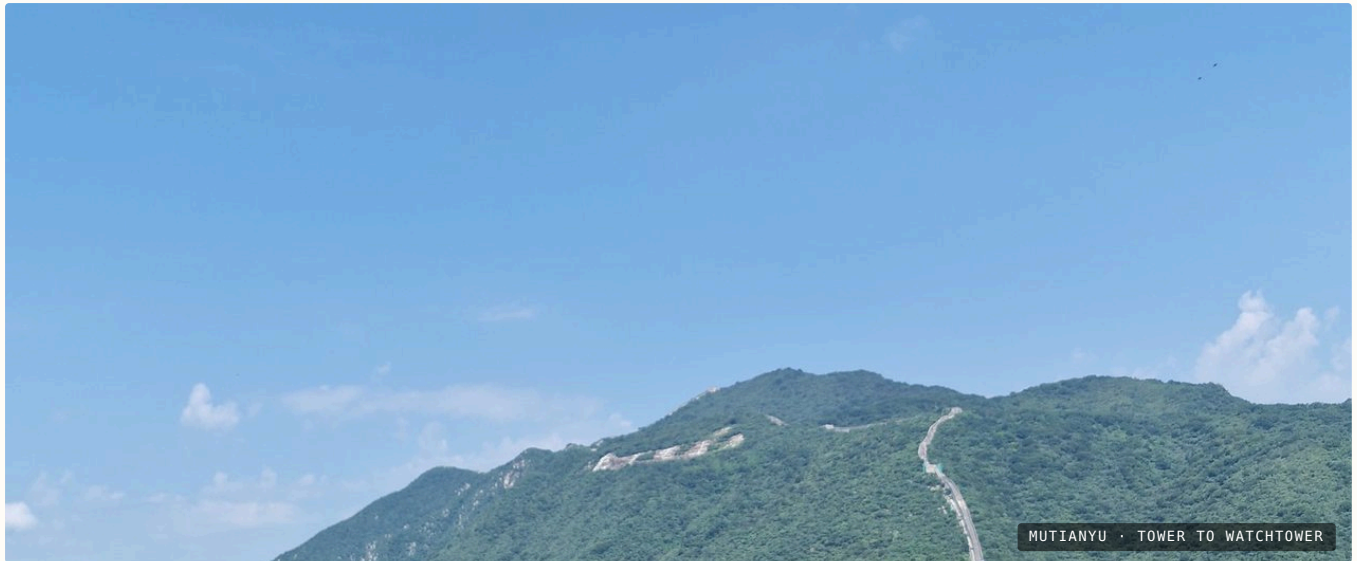
everything pointed at and shared — fresh, generous, and a bill so small we asked twice.

|| The city's legends — lacquered Peking duck, a pavement jianbing, steamer baskets of baozi — we've left on the list. A good reason to come back with more than a stopover. ||

Stone, soldiers, and smoke signals.

Some twenty-one thousand kilometres of wall, raised and rebuilt by dynasty after dynasty across more than two thousand years. On our very last morning we climbed one restored stretch of it — and felt the weight of all the rest.

FRI 7 AUG 2026 MUTIANYU SECTION, HUAIROU HOMEWARD, BY WAY OF THE WALL



Mutianyu under a clear August sky — the restored Wall runs tower to watchtower and then climbs straight up the ridge beyond. After a rainy day in the Forbidden City, the trip ended in brilliant blue — and a blistering 39°C with no shade in sight.

You don't really appreciate the Great Wall from photographs. Photographs flatten it into a ribbon laid neatly across a green landscape. Up close you learn what the camera cannot show: the Wall does not follow the land — it defies it. Where the mountain rises, the Wall rises with it, not at a sensible diagonal but straight up, in staircases steep enough to set you gripping the rail. The sentries who patrolled it did so in armour; the masons who built it dragged their stone up these same slopes.

Ours was a homecoming detour. We had flown back into Beijing before dawn on the last leg of the whole trip, and rather than wait out the day at the airport we drove north to Mutianyu and rode the cable car up around mid-morning. From the top the Wall unspools in both directions, tower to watchtower along the spine of the hills, and within minutes the children had stopped asking how far it went and started asking why anyone would ever build something so vast.

The blue sky came at a price. By late morning it was 39°C on the exposed ramparts, the grey brick throwing the heat straight back up at us and not a

scrap of shade anywhere along the wall. Of the whole month it ranked with our furnace-hot afternoon in the ruins of Pompeii — and Avisha, wilting on the stone, took one look around and christened it "*mini Pompeii*." The name stuck for the rest of the climb.

” The Wall does not follow the mountain. The Wall conquers the mountain. So did the soldiers who stood on it. So did we. ”

What makes Mutianyu special is how much survives. Rebuilt in brick under the Ming — a hard-wearing step up from the rammed earth of earlier dynasties — its watchtowers still hold their arrow-slits, their smoke-signal platforms, and the little stone chambers where soldiers once slept. You can lay a hand on stone six centuries old and feel its cool; you can stand at an arrow-slit and take in the very view a Ming sentinel once scanned, before turning to light a fire and warn the next tower down the line that something was coming.

Good to know.

Two notes for anyone following in our footsteps — how to do a Mutianyu day with young children, and why the Wall was built in the first place.

◆ FIELD NOTES · DOING A MUTIANYU DAY WITH KIDS

HOW IT WORKS

① GETTING THERE

A taxi or private driver from the hotel (about 1½ hours) who **waits at the car park** for the trip back — agree the return fare and waiting time up front. Ask for *Mutianyu* 慕田峪, not Badaling.

③ UP & DOWN BY GONDOLA

Take the enclosed cable car **both ways** to Tower 14 — steady, quick and rain-proof. (The open toboggan slide is a treat, but it closes in the rain.)

⑤ HOW FAR YOU WALK

Barely at all: a shuttle bus from the car park, then a **short flight of steep steps** from the gondola up onto the Wall — after that, stroll as far as tired legs allow and turn back whenever.

② TICKETS — ON THE SPOT

Buy at the entrance windows: *admission + shuttle bus + cable car* together (a combo runs about ¥250 an adult). Or pre-book online to skip the queue. Children under 1.2 m ride the shuttle & cable car free.

④ THE STROLLER

No use up on the Wall — it's all steep stone steps, no ramps. **Leave it in the car** with the driver and carry the little one for the short climb.

⑥ OFF A RED-EYE

Landing before dawn and heading straight out? The gondola-both-ways plan is the least-tiring way to stand on the Wall — no long climb, and the driver minds the bags.

◆ WHY THEY BUILT IT · THE WALL'S JOB

FROM 220 BC

① KEEP THE RAIDERS OUT

Above all, defence — a barrier against the fast horse-nomads of the northern steppe (the Xiongnu, later the Mongols), who raided China's farms for grain and livestock.

③ A GATE ON THE WORLD

Checkpoints controlled who crossed and taxed the Silk Road caravans passing through — the Wall was a customs line as much as a rampart.

② SMOKE BY DAY, FIRE BY NIGHT

Not just a wall but an alarm system: beacon towers relayed a warning from tower to tower, faster than any messenger, that an attack was coming.

④ WHERE CHINA ENDED

It drew a hard border between the settled farmland of the empire and the open grassland beyond — and a road along the top moved troops fast.

And yet it was never quite impassable: in 1279 the Mongols swept over it and in 1644 the Manchus were let through — twice, the people it was built to keep out ended up ruling all of China.

21,196 km

TOTAL LENGTH · ALL DYNASTIES

2,000+ yrs

BUILT & REBUILT ACROSS

Ming

REBUILT MUTIANYU IN BRICK

Tower 14

WHERE OUR GONDOLA LANDED

The country that closed the door.

For most of history China was the richest, most advanced civilisation on earth. Then, for three centuries, it turned its back on the world — and the world, when it finally forced its way in, found a giant that had fallen behind.

THE WALL · FROM 220 BC

The Great Wall you walked at Mutianyu was China's oldest foreign policy, written in stone — a barrier raised over two thousand years to keep out the horse-nomads of the northern steppe. To stand at an arrow-slit is to stand at the edge of the Chinese world, looking out at the very thing it feared.

THE MONGOLS · 1279

And yet the wall was not enough. In 1279 the Mongols under Kublai Khan swept over it and conquered the whole country — the first time all of China was ruled by outsiders. It was in that open, Mongol century that a young Venetian named Marco Polo reached the emperor's court and carried the legend of Cathay home to Europe.

THE CLOSED DOOR · MING & QING

Then China turned inward. The Ming banned private sea trade; the Qing squeezed all foreign commerce through a single gate at Canton. Just as Europe's factories and steamships began to multiply, China sealed itself off, sure it needed nothing from anyone. It was this long shutting of the door — our guide told us — that let the West race ahead and left China behind.

THE RECKONING · 1839–1860

When Britain wanted China's tea and silk and pushed opium in return, and the Qing tried to stop it, the gunboats came. Two Opium Wars shattered the empire, took Hong Kong, and forced the ports open — the start of what China still calls its "Century of Humiliation." The door, shut too long, was now broken off its hinges.

”The land that gave the world paper, printing, gunpowder and the compass — and then, for three hundred years, kept them behind a wall.”

Two stopovers, five childhoods changed.

We had been told China would be a "stopover" — a layover, a bracket around the real trip. That framing turned out to be wrong. Beijing held the trip's biggest history lesson, and the Great Wall its biggest "I cannot believe this is real" moment. If the children remember anything decades from now, it might be this: that the world is impossibly old, that humans have done impossible things, and that you can still climb up onto those things and lay a hand on them and feel that they are real.

What we will carry home: the drum of rain on cheap ponchos in the Forbidden City, the cable car swaying up to the Wall on our very last morning, and the driver who took us to the wrong hotel, then to the right one, and refused a single yuan for the trouble.

FAVOURITE MOMENT

Walking into the Forbidden City at last — the palace I'd only ever seen in the historical dramas I grew up on, suddenly real all around us, in the rain.

HARDEST MOMENT

The fever scare at the airport on the way out — our littlest flagged by the thermal scanner, and the long night flight spent willing his temperature back down.

IF WE COME BACK...

A whole week — Xi'an's terracotta army, and the Great Wall with no plane to catch.

★ NEXT ISSUE ★

AUSTRIA

Hallstatt's salt mines, the Sound of Music hills, and an emperor's marble city by the Danube.

Beijing, China · 10 July + 7 August 2026 · The Grand Journey, 2026